



ASUS Striker

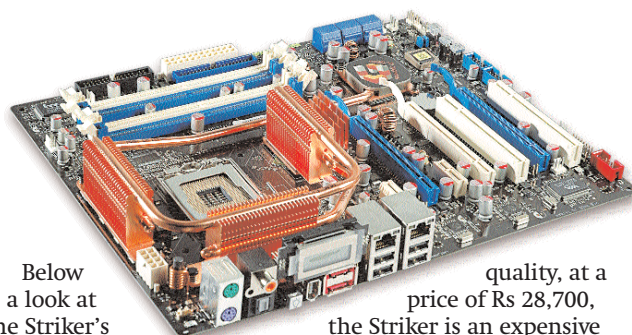
Strike one for the boys in green

Based on NVIDIA's latest 680i chipset, the Striker is ASUS' premium offering. It is targeted at enthusiasts and hardcore gamers. The Striker impresses, with neat frills—like the embedded blue LEDs, and the illuminated On/Off, restart and CMOS reset buttons. The board is most at home inside a see-thru cabinet to be shown off at LAN parties and such.

With all its six SATA ports facing outwards (as opposed to upwards), even a large graphics card won't hamper the functionality of

the ports. ASUS has gone the all-solid-capacitors way on this board, and the substantial-looking heatpipe solution (which does a good job) adds to the appeal the Striker exudes.

You could have a problem trying to install large CPU heatsinks on this board because the heatpipe actually covers the CPU region completely. All the other connectors are very well laid out. A 7.1 soundcard (PCIe x1 interface) is provided, which is necessary considering the packed-to-the-gills PCB.

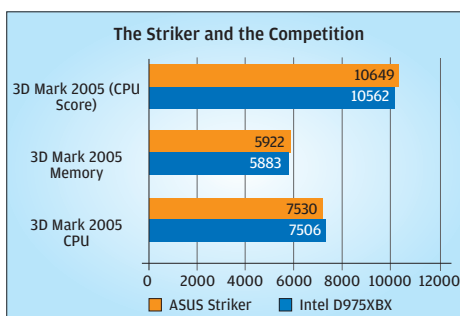


Below is a look at the Striker's performance compared to Intel's high-end 975X platform. Despite the heavy feature set and the supreme build

quality, at a price of Rs 28,700, the Striker is an expensive proposition. Although the venerable nForce 680i chipset is a proven performer now, there are much cheaper options available for the platform.

RATINGS

Performance	★★★★★
Features	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★☆☆
Overall	★★★★★



Specifications

nForce 680i chipset; LGA 775 Socket; supports Core 2 Duo and quad-core processors; six SATA 2.0 ports; rear-panel LCD POST readout

Contact: ASUSTeK Computer
Phone: 022-40058923
E-mail: media_india@asus.com
Web site: www.asus.com
Price: Rs. 28,700

Western Digital My Book Pro Edition II

The terabyte era has begun!

Western Digital sent us something we've never seen, a humongous external drive with—hold your breaths—1 TB (1,000 GB) capacity. That much space is enough to store 75 hours of DV video, 120 hours of HD content, 400 hours of DVD or 2,00,000 MP3 songs.

This sturdily constructed drive has the looks of an extra-large reference book. The drive has a push-button on one side, which lets you take a one-touch backup of your data in conjunction with the provided Retrospect backup software. The button also serves as a capacity gauge.

The My Book Pro appears larger than an average external drive because inside are two WD 5000KS 7200 rpm hard drives, 500 GB each. These drives are

configured so that you can either choose RAID mirroring for extra data protection or RAID striping for speed and performance. RAID configuration is easy with WD's intuitive RAID Wizard.

The My Book sports a triple interface: USB 2.0, FireWire 400, and also the ultra-fast FireWire 800, which has a throughput of 800 MBps. The design of the drive is such that you can stack more such drives in a daisy-chain.

Drive performance, though not the best, was very good—as we had expected. It took just about 45 seconds to transfer a 1 GB sequential file to the drive and 34 to copy it back. Copying a GB to and fro simultaneously took just over a minute and a half.

The bundled Retrospect Express 6.1 backup software can handle all common data backup tasks such as synchronising, incremental, etc. You can schedule these tasks, and it can even do a complete restore of your system if things go terribly wrong. A convection-cooling system driven by a thermostatically-controlled fan keeps the setup cool. The My Book happens to be quite bulky, weighing in at 1.93 kg.

Even though it's 1 TB, the Rs 27,450 price tag will take a toll on your bank balance.



Specifications

1 TB; 2xWD5000KS 7,200 rpm HDD; latency: 4.2 ms; read seek time: 8.9 ms; interfaces: USB 2.0, FireWire 400, and FireWire 800; cables: USB 2.0, IEEE 1394a/b; Dantz Retrospect Express 6.1 backup software; HxDxW: 174.6 mm x 159.3 mm x 104 mm; weight: 1.93 kg

Contact: Mediaman Infotech
Phone: 022-23823100
E-mail: santosh@mediamangroup.com
Web site: www.wdc.com
Price: Rs. 27,450

RATINGS

Performance	★★★★★
Features	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★☆☆
Overall	★★★★★